

with its headquarters at the Ministry of Agriculture and Natural Resources. After the directorate, the next links in the chain of communication are the three Regional Agricultural Officers who are responsible for actual work in their Region. At this level also are found two specialist officers--the Agricultural Aids Officer and the Principal of Colby College. After the Regional Officers come the District Agricultural Officers (DAO), of which there are fifteen in the country. Under the DAO's come Area Supervisors, who are Technicians holding a three-year diploma in Agriculture or its equivalent. The Supervisors, about sixty-two in number, are responsible for the supervision of actual field-contact men, the Technical Assistants. The Technical Assistants must have a two-year certificate in agriculture before they will be employed by the Ministry. In 1971 there were 400 fully-trained Technical Assistants in the country, who were augmented by about 800 demonstrators, partially trained school leavers, who vary in number from time to time. The field staff have a "back-up" of specialists, usually stationed at the Regional headquarters, who can be called on any technical problems which may arise. In 1971 there were twenty-one specialists spread throughout the country.

Outside the development projects there were approximately 819 field staff in Malawi 1972 (ad). They dealt with approximately 805,000 farm families, giving a ratio of extension workers to farm families of approximately 1:1,000. However, a ratio of fully trained field-level workers to farm families is probably nearer average of 1:2,000.

How do the Technical Assistants contact the people? In view of the fact each Technical Assistant has an average of 2,000 farm families, it would seem logical that they spread themselves as far as possible by holding meetings, demonstrations, and the like. In this way the extension staff would make the best use of their most scarce resource--themselves. However, in a breakdown of the three supplied in the three Regional Monthly Reports of November 1972, it does seem as though enough use is being made of group methods. During that month a total of 86,800 individual visits were made, 38,710 people were contacted by group methods, and 1,800 people in the Southern Region took part in organised Radio broadcasts. Again, the published figures for 1969 show that 446,250 farmers were contacted individually and 432,360 by group methods (Malawi 1968-1972). In a debatable if the best method is being used to meet with the situation or if methods are being mixed in the right proportion for greatest effectiveness. In fairness to the extension service, it must be pointed out that the emphasis on the use of individual contacts was the result of a directive from the Government in 1969 (Malawi 1968-1972).

What about the results being obtained? From the published figures of farm and crops sold to ADMARC (Agricultural Development and Marketing Corporation), position seems to be as follows.

In the matter of fertilizer use, the extension service has been very active and successful. The sales of fertilizer rose from 10,919 short tons in 1968-69 to 32,817 short tons in 1971-72. While these are total figures for the whole country, the increases cannot all be attributed to the increased sales of fertilizer on the agricultural development projects and schemes. The same point holds the figures quoted below.